Housekeeping and Organizing Policy

Policy Summary & Knowledge Check

Authority	Board of Directors
Date Ratified	February 2, 2024
Next Review Date	February 2027
Previous Amendments	February 16, 2018; October 30, 2012

Policy Summary

This policy promotes effective, ongoing housekeeping practices in the USC's physical workspace to support accident and fire prevention. It applies to all USC employees, volunteers, and visitors, and covers dust and dirt removal, employee facilities, floor and other surface conditions, lighting, aisles and stairways, spill control, tools and equipment, waste disposal, and storage practices.

Key Takeaways

- Applies to all USC employees, volunteers, and visitors; housekeeping means more than cleanliness — it includes trip-hazard-free floors, proper waste removal, workplace layout, aisle marking, and adequate, ongoing maintenance, since periodic "panic" cleanups are costly and ineffective.
- All employees must keep work areas neat, tidy, and free from trip hazards, ensure garbage/debris are disposed of, remove unused materials, and notify Manager, InfoSource and Building Services if an issue is beyond their control.
- Compressed air must never be used to remove dust, dirt, or chips from equipment or work surfaces; dampening floors before sweeping and manual cleaning of hard-to-reach areas are recommended instead.
- Employee facilities, including student rooms 301, 315, and 318, must be kept adequate, clean, and well maintained; eating areas must be cleaned daily and the fridge is intended for short-term food storage only.
- Floor hazards (spills, chips, worn or damaged flooring) must be addressed promptly, with anti-slip flooring used in areas that can't be continuously cleaned, such as entranceways.
- Aisles and stairways must remain clear of "overflow" storage and be adequately lit; spills should be prevented where possible and cleaned up immediately, with used absorbents disposed of properly.
- Stored materials must not obstruct aisles, stairs, exits, fire equipment, eyewash stations, showers, or first aid stations, must allow at least one meter of clearance under sprinkler heads, and hazardous materials must be stored in approved containers per fire code and OHSA requirements.

Knowledge Check

5 situational questions to check understanding of this policy. An answer key follows on the next page.

Q1. An employee's shelves and light fixtures have accumulated dust that a vacuum can't fully remove. What does the policy recommend?

A. These may require manual cleaning.
B. Leave it until the next scheduled deep clean.
C. Contact the Board of Directors directly.
D. Use compressed air to blow it off quickly.

Q2. Which of the following is explicitly prohibited for removing dust, dirt, or chips from equipment or work surfaces?

A. Dampening floors before sweeping.
B. Compressed air.

C. Manual cleaning.
D. Vacuum cleaners.

Q3. An employee stores personal food in the shared staff fridge for several weeks. Is this consistent with policy?

A. Only frozen items may be stored long-term.
B. Yes, as long as it's labeled.
C. No — the fridge is intended for short-term food storage purposes only.
D. Yes, if it's kept in a sealed container.

Q4. Materials are being stored directly under a sprinkler head in a storage area. What clearance does the policy require?

A. At least 5 feet.
B. No clearance is required.
C. At least 6 inches.
D. At least one meter (about three feet) of clear space.

Q5. An employee notices dim lighting in their work area due to dirty fixtures and burnt-out bulbs. What should they do?

A. Contact Manager, InfoSource and Building Services so the Physical Plant Department can be notified.
B. Ignore it, since it's a minor issue.
C. File a Hazard Reporting Form only if someone is injured.
D. Replace the bulbs themselves without reporting it.

Answer Key

Q1: A — Section 4.1.2 notes that dust and grime collecting on shelves, fixtures, and similar surfaces may require manual cleaning.

Q2: B — Section 4.1.3 states compressed air should not be used for removing dust, dirt, or chips from equipment or work surfaces.

Q3: C — Section 4.2.3 states the fridge is intended for short-term food storage purposes only.

Q4: D — Section 4.9.1 states stored materials should allow at least one meter (or about three feet) of clear space under sprinkler heads.

Q5: A — Section 4.4.1 directs employees to contact Manager, InfoSource and Building Services for dirty fixtures, burnt-out bulbs, or missing lighting covers.